Twenty Famous Chess Positions

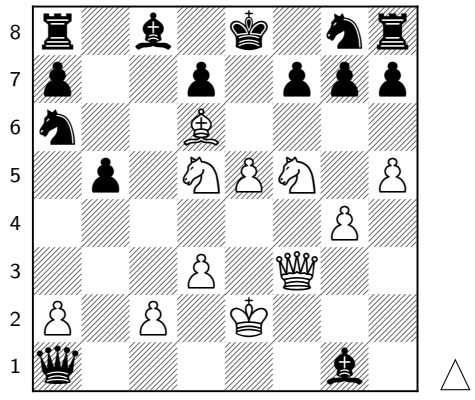
White or Black to play and force checkmate in three moves

How to use this document. Each diagram shows the position with the side to move indicated by the marker beside the board and by the caption. In every position the side to move has a forced checkmate in *exactly* three of its own moves—no faster mate exists, and there is a single winning first move. Try each one before looking at the solutions at the end.

About the positions. Positions 1–5 come from famous games (the Immortal Game, the Evergreen Game, the "Game of the Century", Réti's mate) and from Sam Loyd's celebrated 1859 "Charles XII" problem. Positions 6–20 illustrate classic mating patterns and combinations: back-rank mates, Anastasia's and the Arabian mate, the smothered mate, double check, promotion and under-promotion. These last fifteen are illustrative positions built around those themes rather than transcriptions of specific historic games. Every position was verified by computer (an exhaustive mate-in-three search) to be exactly as described.

1. The Immortal Game

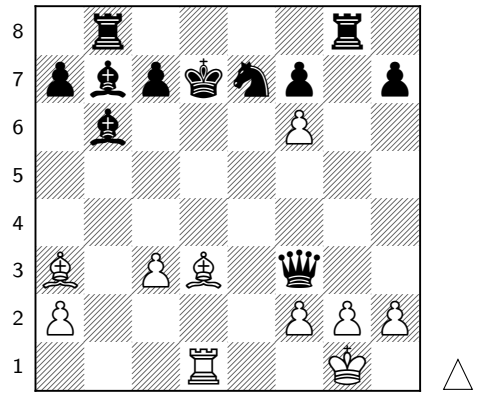
Anderssen – Kieseritzky, London 1851. Position after 20...Na6.



White to play and mate in three

2. The Evergreen Game

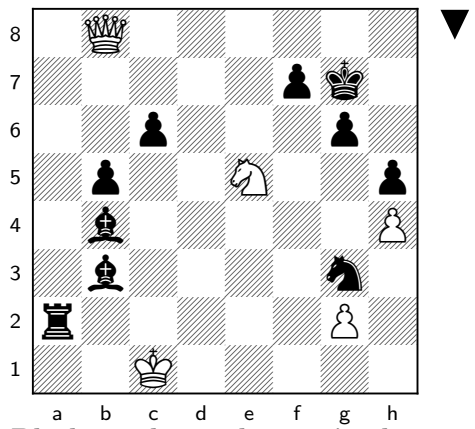
Anderssen – Dufresne, Berlin 1852. Position after 21...Kxd7.



White to play and mate in three

3. The Game of the Century

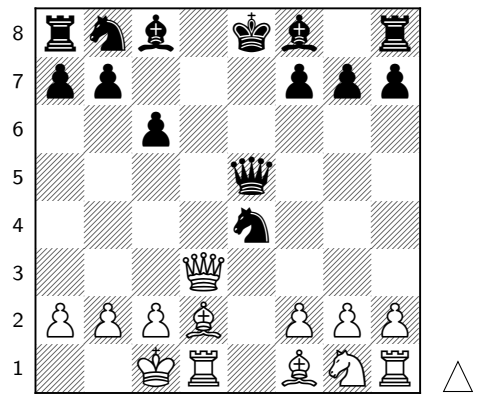
D. Byrne – R. J. Fischer, New York 1956. Position after 39.Kc1.



Black to play and mate in three

4. Réti's Mate

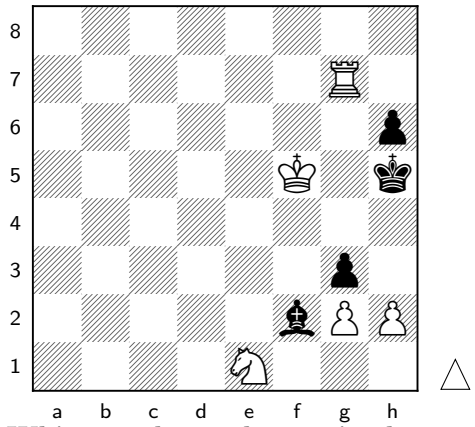
Réti – Tartakower, Vienna 1910. Position after 8...Nxe4.



White to play and mate in three

5. Loyd's Charles XII Problem

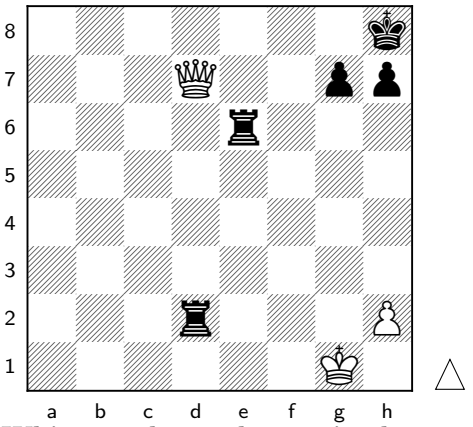
Sam Loyd, 1859.



White to play and mate in three

6. Back-Rank Mate: Queen Sacrifices

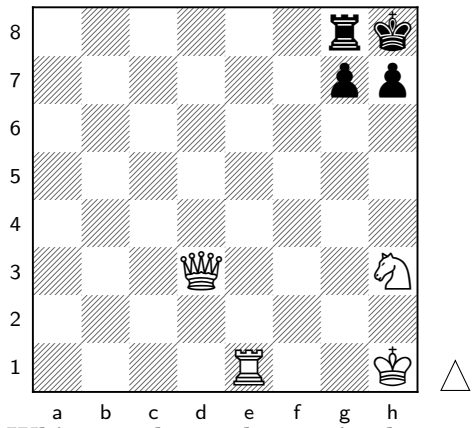
Classic back-rank pattern.



White to play and mate in three

7. Back-Rank Mate: Quiet Knight Move

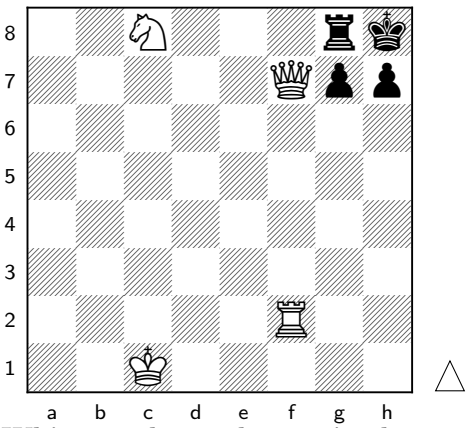
Classic back-rank pattern.



White to play and mate in three

8. Queen Sacrifice and Knight Support

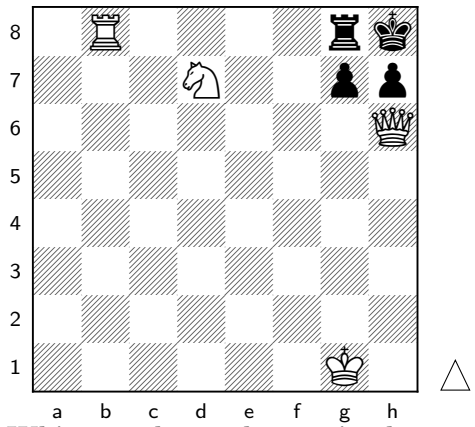
Classic combination.



White to play and mate in three

9. Rook Sacrifice: Queen on the Long Diagonal

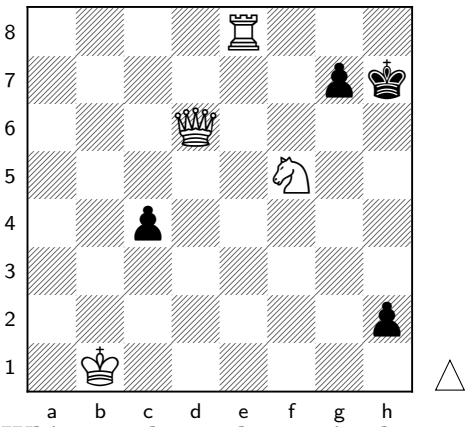
Classic combination.



White to play and mate in three

10. Rook Sacrifice: Queen and Knight Mate

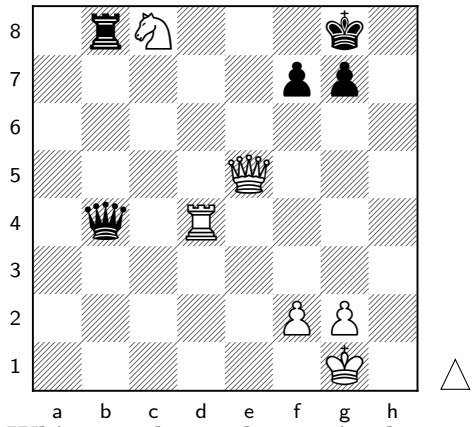
Classic combination.



White to play and mate in three

11. Anastasia's Mate

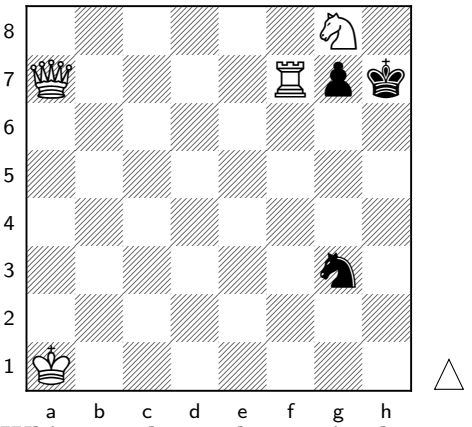
Classic mating pattern.



White to play and mate in three

12. Arabian Mate

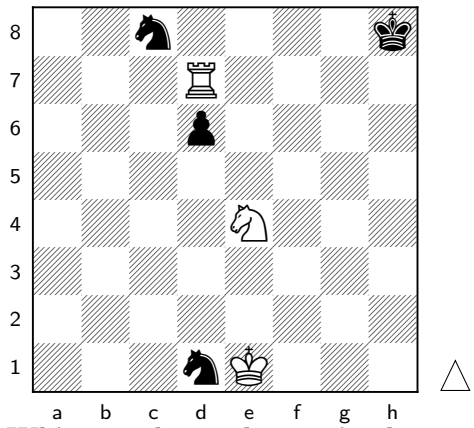
Classic mating pattern.



White to play and mate in three

13. Arabian Mate: Rook Lift

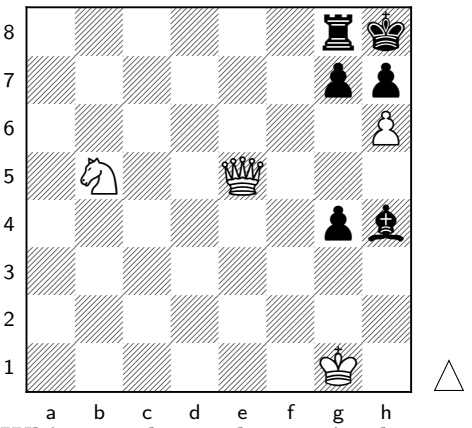
Classic mating pattern.



White to play and mate in three

14. Smothered Mate

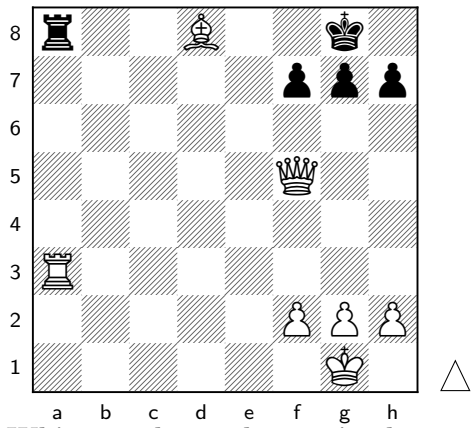
Classic mating pattern.



White to play and mate in three

15. Double-Check Mate

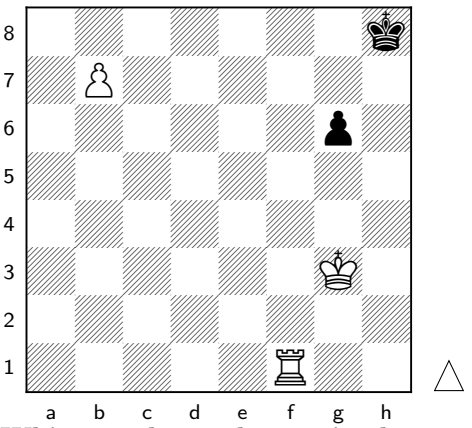
Classic mating pattern.



White to play and mate in three

16. Promotion Mate

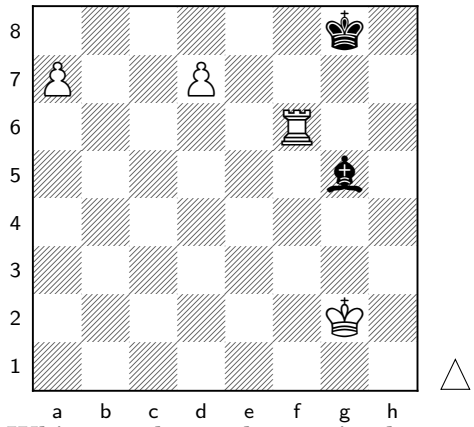
Study-style promotion.



White to play and mate in three

17. Double Promotion

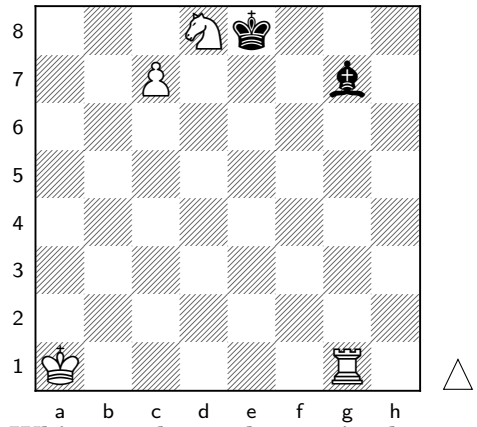
Study-style promotion.



White to play and mate in three

18. Under-Promotion to a Rook

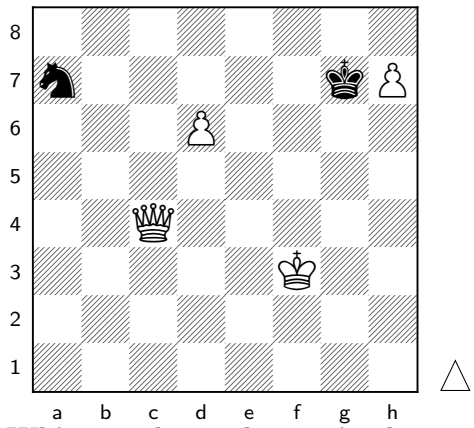
Study-style under-promotion.



White to play and mate in three

19. Under-Promotion to a Bishop

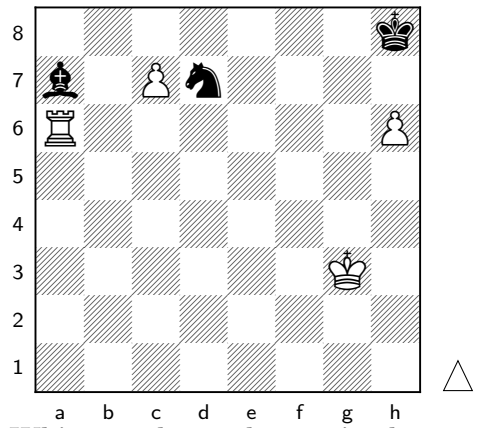
Study-style under-promotion.



White to play and mate in three

20. Promotion, Sacrifice and Queen-and-Pawn Mate

Classic mating pattern.



White to play and mate in three